expose the Congress, why in the 21st century, when everyone is being given their due, should you talk only of one minority. This is again hitting the fabric of the country, number one, to bring division in the polity. This is the beginning of the setting up of the Muslim League's agenda. When you say minorities, *kabhi na kabhi munh se Muslim bhi niklega na*... (you will also say Muslim sometime).

Q. Is that the reason why you are being accused of creating polarisation now, also because the turnout in the first two phases was not that good, trying to energise your cadre...

No, not at all. The challenge that was there in the first two phases was that there was no one in the fight.

Q. There is a feeling that two of your allies–Nitish Kumar in Bihar and Eknath Shinde in Maharashtra–are proving to be weak links. Do you also think they have been given more seats to fight?

No. That is because the alliance (dharma) has to be adhered to as well. Even during the assembly polls (in Bihar), we had supported their candidates. Ours is a cadre-based organisation and we take charge of it. There are several things you have to extend to your partners in alliance. We are on the job, we will manage to win with allies.

Q. The other question is of turncoats fighting on BJP tickets–130-odd out of 445. Doesn't it dilute Brand BJP and exacerbate cultural differences?

You have to understand a few things. Firstly, whenever we induct someone, we analyse in detail what they can bring to the party. Secondly, we are a cadre-based party, yet we do take care of their (turncoat) assimilation so that they integrate well into the system. And our party's system is such that either a person gets settled or goes back. If you speak to the 130-odd who have joined the party, they will tell you that they had never expected that they would get such treatment from the party leadership.

As for our cadre, we explain things to them logically. We select candidates judiciously. The process started in November and we started announcing the names in February.

Q. The BJP has always claimed to be a party with a difference. Why then induct people earlier charged with corruption by the Enforcement Directorate or other agencies and then, once they enter the party, put them through the party washing machine, as the Opposition alleges. Doesn't this dilute Brand BJP too, and make it look like the old Congress...

No, it is not like this. You tell us if we have stopped investigation in a single case. There is no fiddling with the ED, no taming of ED. They have come to our party. Welcome. But the law will take its own course, we respect the law. As for our brand, everyone knows that brand is PM Modi. And they also know Modiji's integrity, his zero tolerance to corruption.

Q. What do you make of the Supreme Court giving interim bail to Arvind Kejriwal but denying the same to Hemant Soren? Do you think Kejriwal's release will impact the polls in Delhi and Punjab?

I don't want to comment on the Supreme Court. But many people are asking these questions. Much has happened since he got bail (the Swati Maliwal controversy). We are increasing our vote share and footprint in Punjab manifold.

Q. Your biggest battle is in Maharashtra where the BJP is accused of engineering splits in the Shiv Sena and NCP and allying with the breakaway factions. Everyone is saying this may cost the party dear, and that the allies may let it down.

Not breakaway, they are the main parties. Their style of functioning may differ, but they are leaders in their own right, so they will get seats in their own way and our cadre will provide them full support.

"THERE IS NO FIDDLING WITH OR TAMING THE ED. ALL THOSE WHO JOINED OUR PARTY ARE WELCOME. BUT THE LAW WILL TAKE ITS OWN COURSE"

Q. How confident is the BJP of doing well in the remaining states going to the polls, namely, West Bengal, Bihar, UP and Odisha?

In West Bengal, we will improve our tally. Mamata is exposed. People are frustrated. Even the *bhadralok* have understood that Bengal has no future. In Bihar, under the leadership of Nitish Kumar... he has credibility, the rest we are confident our cadre will pull through. In UP, we are doing really well. Last time, we (NDA) had 64 (seats); this time, we will do much better. In Odisha, we are confident of forming the government. The BJD may win a seat here or there, but the BJP will sweep the state. There is an anti-Pandian and anti-BJD wave in the state. People in the BJD itself are frustrated.

Q. The BJP, especially PM Modi, has put in a lot of effort in the southern states. Now that voting is over in these states, what is your feedback?

In the South, we are opening our account with more than one seat in Tamil Nadu. In Andhra, we are winning four, and may get the fifth one as well. Since the TDP has returned to the NDA, we will sweep the polls there. In Telangana, our strength has already doubled. We are maintaining our numbers in Karnataka and, in Kerala, we are winning more than one seat.

Q. So, what is the figure you are finally going with?

Four hundred plus. ■